All matters at any sitting of either House or joint sitting of both the Houses are decided by a majority of votes of the members present and voting, excluding the presiding officer. Only a few matters, which are specifically mentioned in the Constitution, require either effective majority or special majority, not simple majority.

The presiding officer of a House does not vote in the first instance, but exercises a casting vote in the case of an equality of votes. The proceedings of a House are to be valid irrespective of any unauthorised voting or participation or any vacancy in its membership.

The following points can be noted with respect to the voting procedure in the Lok Sabha:

1. On the conclusion of a debate, the Speaker shall put the question and invite those who are in favour of the motion to say 'Aye' and those against the motion to say 'No'.

2. The Speaker shall then say: 'I think the Ayes (or the Noes, as the case may be) have it.' If the opinion of the Speaker as to the decision of a question is not challenged, he/she shall say twice: The Ayes (or the Noes, as the case may be) have it' and the question before the House shall be determined accordingly.

3. **(a)** If the opinion of the Speaker as to the decision of a question is challenged, he/she shall order that the Lobby be cleared.

(b) After the lapse of three minutes and thirty seconds, he/she shall put the question a second time and declare whether in his/her opinion the 'Ayes' or the 'Noes' have it.

(c) If the opinion so declared is again challenged, he/she shall direct that the votes be recorded either by operating the automatic vote recorder or by using 'Aye' and 'No' Slips in the House or by the Members going into the Lobbies.

4. If in the opinion of the Speaker, the Division is unnecessarily claimed, he/she may ask the members who are for 'Aye' and those for 'No' respectively to rise in their places and, on a count being taken, he/she may declare the determination of the House. In such a case, the names of the voters shall not be recorded.



Methods of Voting

The various methods adopted for voting in the Lok Sabha are explained below[13b]:

1. ***Voice Vote:*** It is a simple method for deciding a question put by the Speaker on a motion made by a member. Under this method, the question before the House is determined by the 'Ayes' or the 'Noes', as the case may be.

2. ***Division:*** There are three methods of holding a Division. These are:

(a) By operating the Automatic Vote Recording Equipment;

(b) By distributing 'Ayes' and 'Noes' slips in the House; and

(c) By members going into the Lobbies.